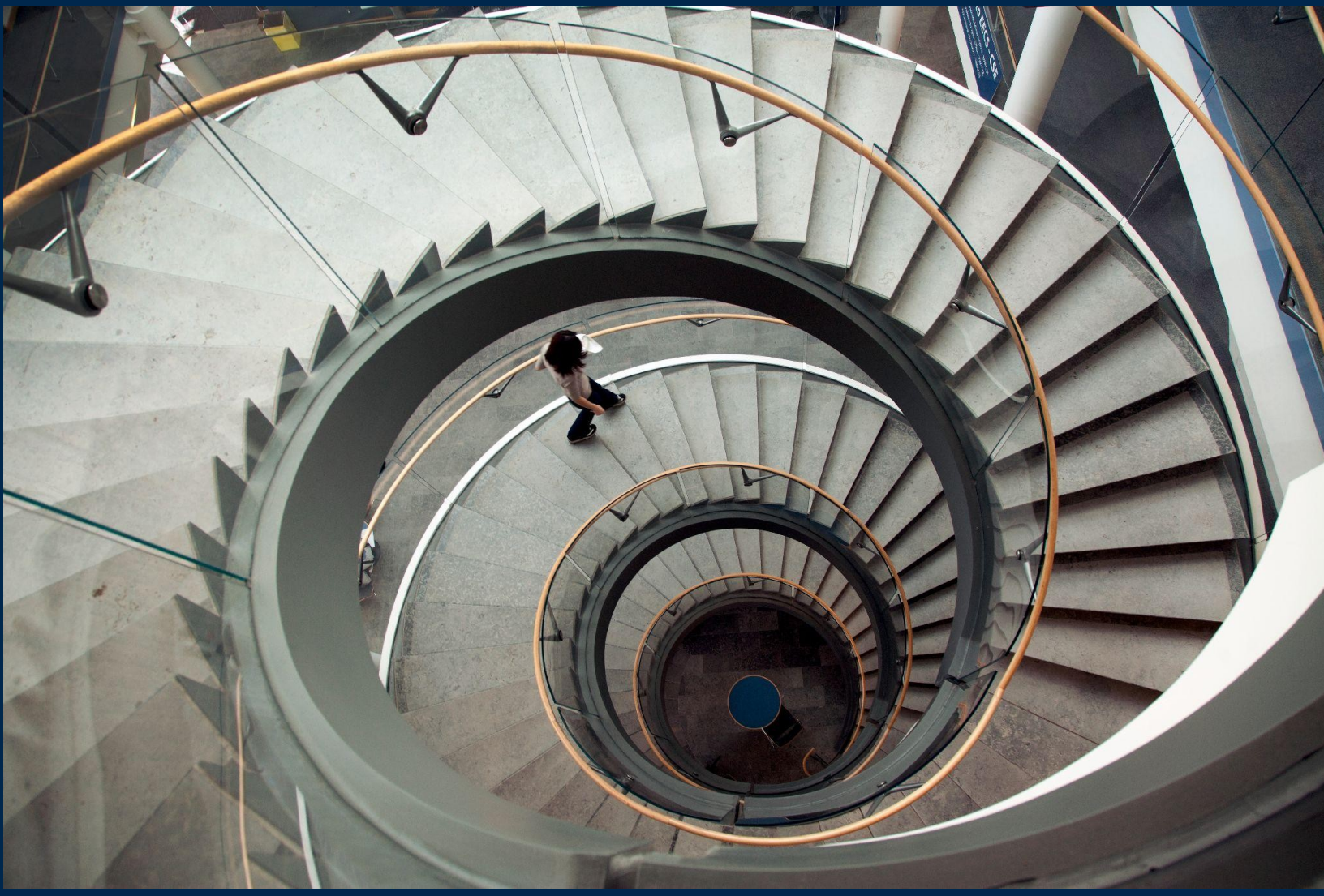
Archivists in the Loop

Archival Reference Practices and Artificial Intelligence



Symposium Report

BENTLEY HISTORICAL LIBRARY
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Jesse Johnston and Meghan Courtney are the project directors. They conceived of the idea for a symposium on AI and archival reference services, and they gained the institutional support required to make the gathering feasible. They convened the advisory team, and together this group developed a list of participants based on their knowledge of projects and work in archival reference. Jess Farrell co-designed and co-facilitated the symposium and was an equal contributor in the writing and editing of the report.

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Executive Summary

On June 4 and 5, 2026, a group of thirty practitioners, scholars and technologists gathered in Ann Arbor, Michigan to discuss the implications of AI on archival reference work. The Archivists in the Loop symposium, sponsored by the Bentley Historical Library and the University of Michigan School of Information, convened a small and interactive group to discuss archival reference interactions, access systems, and how AI is changing user needs.[1] This report summarizes the themes and recommendations of the gathering.

The symposium generated the following recommendations, which are discussed in greater detail throughout the report.

1. Archivists should identify opportunities to shape AI tools and workflows for archives in ways that advance archival values.

2. Archivists should engage in user studies that examine AI-assisted information seeking behavior in order to meet users where they are. These studies might gauge how researchers use AI tools, evaluate AI-generated information, and where confusion or loss of context may occur. They may also help us understand when users most need human intervention.

3. Shared guidance for archivists working with AI tools, developed in collaboration with our colleagues in UX and HCI specialties, is needed. Additionally, the group saw opportunities for tools, practices, and standards developed by or in collaboration with the archival community that focus on minimal computing.

4. Archives should disclose their own use of AI and help users understand AI's limitations when working with archival material, much of which is unique and not digitized.

5. Future conversations should address how archivists can balance commitments to access with concerns about data extraction, privacy, cultural sensitivity, intellectual property, and the potential misuse of archival materials.

[1] By AI, we mean the broad suite of technologies and tools that are based in or powered by Large Language Models (LLMs) and generally characterized as "generative AI."

About the Symposium

Purpose and Goals

While the implications of AI on society have been a major topic of discussion across disciplines, the impacts and potentials of AI tools in archival reference have not been fully explored. Recent discussions have developed in the professional community writ large.[2] The *Archivists in the Loop* symposium specifically addressed archival reference through facilitated, participatory discussions focused on archival description, reference and access services, and technology. This report summarizes the symposium's key discussions and observations and asks for feedback from the field.

Participants

The team chose participants who represented a broad range of specializations, including reference archivists, developers, metadata specialists, students, and scholars from academic archives. Participants had varying perspectives on AI, and many had done prior work considering the relationships between AI and archival access and reference.

Throughout the symposium, a recurring theme was who was not in the room. The organizers acknowledged that this first meeting is a starting point, and the group committed to developing ways for more people to participate in future discussions. In particular, the group discussed the desire to collaborate across government, community, business archives, public libraries, and historical societies. This report is a first step to communicate the knowledge this group developed, however limited their perspectives may be, and to establish a shared understanding of what we are exploring and working toward.

Framing

To bridge the gap between differing positions and perspectives, organizers asked participants to review a small set of pre-readings and additional resources (see Appendix I). This established a shared frame of reference for discussion.

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[2] The University of Virginia Archival AI Protocol
https://libraopen.library.virginia.edu/handle/item/9725
The Council of State Archivists 2026 Electronic Records Day poster and white paper on AI in the Archives, which addresses reference as one of three core areas that AI is changing archival work:
https://edge.growthzonecms.com/sites/2163/2026/10/2026-10-01_ERecsDayPoster.jpg

Together, these readings created a focus for the conference: while archivists emphasize providing trustworthy and accessible means for users to interact with archival materials, these practices have been largely developed with analog content in mind, whereas researchers, and even archivists themselves, have often integrated generative AI tools in their processes. This shaped inter-related questions in advance of the symposium:

- How do reference archivists keep up with user behavior changes in order to meet user needs? With many researchers integrating various AI tools into their work, how can archivists provide reliable and equitable access to collections both analog and digital, even when collections may never be completely discoverable within the digital environment?
- How can archivists contribute to the conversation around developing responsible and ethical AI tools and uses?
- What areas of AI, if any, do reference archivists need to better understand, and how can they communicate their knowledge with users?
- How can archivists maintain a critical approach to AI while seeking constructive opportunities to align AI tools with archival values?

Event Overview and Emergent Themes

Archival Reference Services Past and Present

The symposium opened with a keynote by Professor Wendy Duff, who reflected on her longstanding research work focused on the tools and practices of archival access and reference.[3] Duff emphasized that archival reference is often overlooked in the field of archival research. In her presentation, Duff emphasized that reference archivists have continually adapted their approaches and practices to meet new technologies and researcher behaviors. In some ways, the current moment — when researchers are using AI tools before contacting reference staff, and library technology is increasingly incorporating AI — is simply the latest iteration of this phenomenon.

Duff asked the group to consider:

[3] While Duff's work in this area is varied, she specifically framed her remarks on how AI tools may, or may not, fit into the Archival Reference Knowledge model (ARK), as outlined in Wendy M. Duff, Elizabeth Yakel, and Helen Tibbo, "Archival Reference Knowledge," *American Archivist* 76 (2013): 68–94; doi: 10.17723/aarc.76.1.x9792xp27140285g.

- What do we need to relearn in order to support students and other researchers conducting archival reference while utilizing AI?
- How can our expertise grow and change to meet our users and systems where they are and where they will be?
- Where do archivists and AI fit into the Archival Reference Knowledge (ARK) Model?

Duff's talk at the top of the symposium emphasized a focus on the user interactions and support provided through reference interactions. Group discussions noted that the purpose of reference services in archives and special collections libraries has always been to connect users to archival materials. Rather than serving as experts in the field, reference archivists guide patrons through the sometimes opaque process of researching in the archives. A skilled reference archivist can elicit additional information to better support them. Reference interviews offer opportunities to build connection and trust by incorporating curiosity, patience, and listening to understand. Given that archival materials remain overwhelmingly analog, most AI models don't have access to enough detailed data to create these connections.

With the growing use of generative AI models from all types of researchers–from experienced researchers who have visited the archives many times, to someone who has never heard of an archive at all – the need for a space for reference archivists to share resources is vital.

Project Lightning Talks

The opening presentation on archival reference practices was followed by a series of presentations and related discussions on current initiatives that involve AI and access to archival materials. Topics ranged from the development and implementation of new systems to techniques that foster discussions and increase awareness about AI's impact on reference services.

Meg McMahon reported on *Collections Explorer*, a new interface for Harvard Library's special collections and archives that integrates AI-generated summaries of finding aid components and responds to natural language queries input by users.[4] More information on the platform is available at https://library.harvard.edu/services-tools/collections-explorer.

[4] An article by Caizzi and Deschenes describes the development and planning for this project; https://doi.org/10.5860/ital.v45i1.17511.

Paul Gallagher introduced Western Michigan University's *South Haven Lighthouse Logs* project, which used a multi-step AI-enhanced workflow to clean scanned images of nineteenth-century lighthouse keeper logs and generate Optical Character Recognition (OCR) text. Additional processes produced structured data (including weather and condition reports) and summaries of the daily entries. The project is available at https://southhavenlighthouselogs.com/.

Hannah Scates Kettler described the *Responsible AI Practice in Libraries and Archives* project's ViewFinder tool, which was designed to facilitate ethical reflection about responsible AI in libraries and archives. The tool fosters values-based conversations to better understand the perspectives of various stakeholders as they relate to the role of AI in archives. In addition to contributing articles on the topic to various journals, the project team has made ViewFinder available at https://www.lib.montana.edu/responsible-ai/[5].

Lindsay Hartman discussed *SisGPT*, a Graph-RAG tool in development at Louisiana State University for exploring collections of complex business records in an educational context. To improve users' information-seeking, SisGPT offers semantic search powered by LLMs as well as results linked to a controlled database.

After the lightning talks, participants engaged in an open discussion about what AI projects they are working on now, what AI projects they are thinking about starting, and what assumptions they are making about information literacy or information seeking behavior in those projects.

While each project illustrated different features and capacities of AI-enhanced access systems, there was a consistent emphasis on targeted and clearly-scoped open source tools. A key takeaway was that such resources – as opposed to large, off-the-shelf commercial tools and foundation models – facilitate the integration of archivally-informed and -driven development principles in AI-driven projects.[6]

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[5] Recent contributions from the Responsible AI Practice in Libraries and Archives team include *Journal of eScience Librarianship* 13 (1): e860 DOI: https://doi.org/10.7191/jeslib.860 and Mannheimer, S., Bond, N., Young, S. W. H., Kettler, H. S., Marcus, A., Slipher, S. K., Sheehey, B. (2024). Responsible AI Practice in Libraries and Archives: A Review of the Literature. *Information Technology and Libraries*, 43(3). https://doi.org/10.5860/ital.v43i3.17245

[6] Foundation model refers to large language models trained on vast datasets, for which sources and weights are often undisclosed due to corporate interests or other reasons.

Reference and Access Systems

Participants discussed what a minimum viable reference workflow looks like, and how AI might interact with that workflow. Most participants said reference interviews should always be done by a human, though there may be tools the archivist and/or user could use to support or enhance the interview. Archival research often requires a grappling with uncertainty and gaps in the record that most AI tools were not designed for. Some also felt that archivists must facilitate ***access to physical collections***.

Participants suggested that adding AI tools to the workflow might make the most sense when triaging incoming requests, providing accessibility options, or making provenance more visible.

Intentional and Informed Innovation

Attendees identified data-sharing as a potential area of focus, such as the exchange of finding aids through systems searching shared data across organizations, or consortial/cross-field practices around how EAD is used, and other methods of "un-siloing" data. One related concept that emerged was the dream of a "metadata lake" for mapping across different sources and standards.

Archival values and principles can be intentionally leveraged in imagining and designing AI-enhanced archival reference systems:

- **Provenance** might be reflected in systems which verify archival (and other) citations, offering up proof, transparency, trust and authenticity.
- The concept of **archival silences** might be reinterpreted and expanded in the ways tools and systems provide transparency around the absence of relevant search results, perhaps designing tools with the ability to identify and indicate the non-presence of undigitized materials in its training data.
- **Archival systems** might reflect components of the human reference interaction, trained to indicate to a user when it's time to speak to a (human) archivist, building in a "dial 0 for Human" option.
- Archival expertise in **donor agreements**, individual **privacy** and **cultural agency** would contribute to mitigation of privacy risks in AI tools.

Broadly, attendees noted that archivists and archival users would benefit from AI tools and features developed with input from the archival profession and targeted to meet specific

user and community needs rather than corporate or third-party tools created outside of the archival ecosystem. This was a sentiment borne out in practice, as evidenced by the bespoke AI interfaces, workflows and tools demonstrated in the symposium's lightning talks.

Archival Reference Purpose and Values

Many of the core purposes and associated values that emerged from the activity centered around archivists' work to *help, support, facilitate, or connect:*

Archivists want to *help* people access and understand archival sources and information, particularly those they may not be able to access on their own. They also want to help users understand how our archival systems function.

Archivists *support* scholarship and storytelling by providing access to high-quality data/primary sources, in ways that allow for a wide range of historical research questions and methods. Archivists also *support* communities by responsibly stewarding and providing access to collections relevant to their needs.

Archivists *facilitate* access to information and archival collections to promote a more informed and educated public, a more democratic society, and a wider variety of possible futures. Attendees recognized that access to and understanding of archives may not be as straightforward as users expect. The archivist's role in facilitating access may be to complicate users' understanding of our collections and what they can learn from them.

Archivists *connect* users to trustworthy information, their archival "spark", and to other people, whether archives staff, fellow users or community members. Multiple participants emphasized that meaningful, inclusive reference interactions are essential to establish these connections and gain users' trust. While many attendees felt AI tools could help archivists manage or triage reference work, all agreed that people are key to the profession and must remain central.

Archival Labor

On the second day of the symposium, small groups discussed AI's impact on archival labor. Participants agreed that AI systems should always be used in ways that augment rather than replace human experiences.

Gains

New tools and having more time or increasing efficiency were the top emerging themes around possible gains from AI. Specific potential gains for labor in reference work included:

- Identifying **new opportunities to meet user needs**, lower barriers, and expand our ability to be more inclusive of users or groups who haven't always felt welcomed in special collections and archives. Examples included shy users and users requiring translation for reference support or to access documents.
- The potential for natural language prompts to **facilitate discovery across different types of user groups** (beyond academics) by encouraging users to shape queries however they feel most comfortable expressing themselves.
- Ways of programmatically meeting needs we could not previously address, such as incorporating linked data into description.

Losses

Participants expressed concerns about losing time and connection with users, especially for information discovery. Identified potential losses included:

- Users' potential **loss of trust in archivists**, our descriptions, and our perceived relevancy when AI is used in reference interactions. The symposium pre-event survey confirmed that this is happening in some interactions.
- **Losses in efficiency** as researchers lose literacy in the discovery phase of research. When researchers use AI as their only or primary discovery tool to find archives, it shifts more labor to reference workers. Archivists spend a growing amount of time trying to verify the existence of collections and parse users' research goals.
- **Loss of a connection between the reference user and the reference archivist**.
    - Loss of facilitation and sense of stewardship in information retrieval.
    - Relatedly, participants expressed a concern around the "right to be forgotten," and archives' ability to manage data removal.

- **Loss of research skills and users' ability to discover unexpected material**. Traditionally, the discovery process has included pathways for colocation and serendipitous identification of related material in and across collections.
- **Losing visibility for materials that cannot be digitized** or are not well represented in archival description. Using an LLM as part of a discovery system, the results will be limited to published descriptions whereas reference workers have access to numerous systems that aid in discovery (e.g. box lists, accession records, ArchivesSpace, institutional knowledge).

Trust

In small groups, participants discussed the concept of trust, considering:

- How does AI affect researchers' trust in archives and archivists?
- What does this mean for interactions between archivists and researchers?

Participants raised concerns about **trust in record authenticity and accuracy**. Reference archivists have encountered AI-assisted records and descriptions that include hallucinations of incorrect information and even hallucinations of documents themselves.

Participants discussed **trust between users and archivists**. Archivists can cultivate trust with users by working with AI to fully understand the tools. They can encourage users' responsible and informed use of AI tools. To maintain trust, uses of AI should align with the needs of user communities and with considerations for privacy and safeguarding cultural heritage.

Participants also discussed how AI affects **trust in archival institutions and organizations**. To maintain trust at the institutional level, archives must disclose when and how AI is in use, which models are used, how results are generated, and how responses or results can be verified or traced. Ideally, both institutions and AI outputs should highlight the availability of analog-only archival material.

How does AI change **trust in the archival profession** itself? Attendees emphasized that broad participation is necessary for developing useful guidelines to foster trust in the archival profession in the AI landscape. Suggestions included connections with working groups, regional archives, and professions with similar or overlapping responsibilities (in particular, UX librarians and Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) researchers). The discussion also surfaced the need to address technology skills gaps among archives

professionals, the importance of including perspectives from organizations with fewer resources or minimal computing, and understanding global perspectives and cultural differences on AI. These endeavors are important not only to build trustworthy approaches to AI, but also to cultivate and maintain trust in archival professional organizations themselves.

Participants also discussed **trust in technology outputs and governance**. Considering the trustworthiness of AI technology itself, participants suggested designing tools that allow AI responses to include provenance and contextual information, such as what collection data is not available to training models, alerting users to the presence of undigitized materials, or providing a confidence score for search results.

The group also recognized that AI tools exist within a context of underlying technology infrastructures such as data centers, which are placing many communities and environments under great stress. In this context, are there ways to minimize the harmful impacts of AI while still obtaining its benefits, such as by using smaller locally run models where possible? A comprehensive discussion of trust requires considering the second and third order effects of AI work, as well as the second and third order effects of not making use of AI.

Lastly, attendees observed that, beyond archival contexts, we are living in a moment where there is a significant amount of distrust in systems, institutions, and information. Responses to AI may be influenced by this broader milieu as well as its specific impacts.

Authenticity, Transparency, and Openness

In order to best position AI tools as part of archival practice, it is important that there be mechanisms with which to discern the quality of AI output, to indicate where absences exist in the data from which the AI draws, and the functional ability for the tool to prompt a user to refer to a human in support of their query. In order for the tool to be useful and accurate, the user (and the tool) must know its limits. Given the general lack of information about models, data, and process for many of the more ubiquitous commercial AI platforms and tools, this is currently not a feasible benchmark.

As archival tools are developed with accuracy as a core tenet, we may see the ability to reproduce, back-trace and visualize outputs in a way that better satisfies the need of the community for accurate information and representation of archival materials. In access

systems, it is important to disclose to users, both archivists and end users, where AI has been used to process or generate summaries, search results, or other discovery products.

Transparency has been a throughline of conversation among archival practitioners. Archivists have debated how and to what extent to describe archival interventions and positionality, particularly in balance with labor and efficiency. Disclosure is useful for reference archivists receiving inquiries, because it can help them understand the context and priorities of a request. It is not surprising that this concept emerged as a primary theme at the symposium, particularly as transparency has become a major part of the national and global dialogues around AI.

Interestingly, there was equal emphasis placed on the need to prioritize robust archival description rather than "light processing" because AI models train on digital content that is available to them. This acknowledgement of agency underscored a connection between archival practice in the AI ecosystem and of the notion that bad data equates to bad-data outputs of these systems. If archival materials are not processed and digitized or are only minimally described in digital form, these archival silences may be reflected in the accuracy, quality and content of AI-generated results.

Transparency is critical for evaluating AI-assisted reference work. This confirms the importance of transparency as an aspect of basic AI literacy for archival users predicated on the transparency provided by the system or tool itself. In order to effectively engage with AI tools, backend details to help support the ideal of transparency are needed, including minimal information about data included in models, decision trees or indicators of inflection points or events that triggered the outputs generated.[7]

AI Literacy

Archival description is a challenge to new users of archives who are unfamiliar with finding aids and navigating archival data.[8] Discovery that is mediated by AI tools, whether

[7] Transparency is already identified as a key element of the ACRL's AI Literacy framework, in the area of ethics. However, our discussions pointed out that transparency in addition must be a component of system design and implementation. See Lo, "AI Literacy: A Guide for Academic Libraries," *College & Research Libraries News* 86 (2025), doi:https://doi.org/10.5860/crln.86.3.120. Competencies are frequently identified as elements of professional work, for example, the Rare Books and Manuscripts Section of ALA publishes "Competencies for Special Collections Professionals."

[8] For example, see Wendy M. Duff and Catherine A. Johnson, "Accidentally Found on Purpose: Information-Seeking Behavior of Historians in Archives," *The Library Quarterly* 72, no. 4 (2002): 472–96. http://www.jstor.org/stable/40039793.

user-selected chatbots or library-created discovery tools, requires archivists to offer different types of support to users. While many new users find a chatbot's suggestions for archival search comfortable and supportive, this does not always translate to success when a researcher requests a physical box and takes a look at the contents. Archivists need to study these evolving discovery methods and identify moments for intervention and support. Research literacy has traditionally been focused on developing human researchers' knowledge and skills. Evolving literacy methods may be directed at AI tools as well as human users.

Recommendations

The ideas below represent areas of emerging consensus from symposium discussions for approaching work with AI, policy changes, and user interactions. They are not intended as final prescriptions, but as shared starting points for future research, guidance, and collective action.

1. Approach AI decisions and conversations without binaries

The discussions reflected a shared sense that generative AI is neither wholly "good" nor "bad" for archives and archivists. For many organizations, AI tools may facilitate accessibility and discoverability that would otherwise be out of reach through currently available resourcing or existing processes. Archivists have both an opportunity and professional obligation to engage critically.

Future work must **remain attentive to the risks AI poses while also identifying opportunities to shape AI tools and workflows for archives in ways that advance archival values**. As one participant put it: "Things are not binary when it comes to AI and archives." Another emphasized that "AI should serve the needs of human archivists," including their judgment, expertise, and ethical responsibilities, "not replace them."

2. Better understand users and AI-assisted research

Participants agreed that archivists need more information about how users actually employ AI in archival research. Because researchers increasingly encounter archival materials through search engines, chatbots, and other external systems, archivists have a limited view into the pathways that bring users to specific collections or questions.

Future work should include **user studies that examine AI-assisted information seeking *before* users contact an archive**. These studies could help archivists understand how researchers use AI tools, how they evaluate AI-generated information, and where confusion, loss of context, or misinterpretation may occur. Studies may also help us understand when users most need human intervention. We know that users are engaging in AI-assisted information seeking; our goal is to meet users where they are and help bridge knowledge gaps around how AI-assisted research works with the support of human reference archivists.

3. Develop shared professional guidance and collective capacity

Participants emphasized the need for shared guidance for archivists working with or alongside AI tools. Rather than relying solely on commercial systems that were not designed around archival values, the group saw opportunities for tools, practices, and standards developed by or in collaboration with the archival community.

Future work could include **developing practical guidance, shared evaluation criteria, professional development resources, and cross-institutional conversations about responsible AI use in archival reference and access, via collective action**. Participants emphasized the need for collective action across a range of archives and libraries to ensure that archival values help shape emerging AI systems and practices.

4. Prioritize provenance, traceability, and context

Participants agreed that AI-mediated access **tools must preserve the provenance, traceability, and context of archival sources** to be useful in archival research. Users should be able to understand where information comes from, how it was generated, and how AI-generated responses connect back to archival sources and metadata. This will require archives to disclose their own use of AI and help users understand AI's limitations when working with archival material, much of which is unique and not digitized.

As a baseline, future work should **define expectations for citations, including provenance and source traceability, in AI-enabled discovery and reference tools**. Users should be able to determine if returned information is machine-generated, inferred, uncertain, or drawn from specific archival descriptions or materials.

5. Rethinking Openness for the Common Good

Participants were concerned about the security and governance of publicly available archival materials in an environment of bots, web scraping, and large-scale data aggregation. Archives have long made descriptive information and content for digitized and born-digital materials available online to support access, but generative AI raises new questions about how those materials may be harvested, reused, or incorporated into training datasets without institutional awareness or donor and community consent.

Future conversations should address **how archivists can balance commitments to access with concerns about data extraction, privacy, cultural sensitivity, intellectual property, and the potential misuse of archival materials**.[9] These questions are especially pressing for collections involving vulnerable individuals, historically marginalized communities, or materials made available under assumptions that predate contemporary AI systems.

Toward collective action

Together, the group's recommendations and dream projects point toward a practical agenda for archival reference in this AI moment: understand how users are already engaging with AI, build shared professional guidance before norms are set elsewhere, and insist that AI-mediated access preserve the provenance, traceability, and context on which archival trust depends. Participants also identified opportunities for continued collaboration, including a statement of principles--or "manifesto"--outlining core competencies, risks, opportunities, and values for archival reference and AI.

These actions will be most effective if they are truly collective; that is, if they encompass all the voices that are part of the archival reference enterprise, including reference archivists, technologists, managers and end users.

[9] Important to note the recent "rethink open" conversation; this has recently been featured on the Future Knowledge series - https://futureknowledge.transistor.fm/. These conversations may build on principles outlined in the Vancouver Statement (https://collectionsasdata.github.io/part2whole/vancouver/).

Conclusion

Archival reference services are rapidly changing as generative AI tools become widely used by researchers as well as archivists. As we adapt, we must learn and develop new practices for meeting users' needs together.

Archivists in the Loop brought people together to identify core changes in reference interactions we are seeing now, make recommendations on what we need to move forward as a profession, and create new resources that could help us and other professionals navigate the changing landscape. Resources and ideas from the event are chronicled at https://bentley-historical-library.github.io/archivists-in-the-loop/. We will continue to update this space as we build community and resources for archival reference in the age of artificial intelligence.

A community of practice serendipitously grew from the symposium. Everyone was eager to continue the work together after the convening, and we hope to maintain this interest in the near future. We join other communities across libraries, archives, and museums engaged in research and knowledge sharing on different aspects of AI in our profession to forge a path forward.

Appendices

I. Readings

Prior to the symposium, we circulated the following resources as "pre-read" materials:

- Duff, Wendy M., Elizabeth Yakel, and Helen Tibbo, "Archival Reference Knowledge," American Archivist 76 (2013):68–94. DOI: 10.17723/aarc.76.1.x9792xp27140285g.
- Jesse A. Johnston and Meghan Courtney, "Archival Reference Services in an Age of AI," Collections: A Journal for Museum and Archives Professionals, online first. DOI: 10.1177/15501906261439244.
- Ed Summers, "Some things to consider when deciding whether to start building with 'AI' in libraries and archives", 12 March 2024, available at https://inkdroid.org/2024/03/12/ai/.
- Emilie Hardman, "Like It or Not, AI Has Arrived in Archives," Katina Magazine (March 2026), available at https://katinamagazine.org/content/article/open-knowledge/2026/like-it-or-not-ai-has-arrived-in-archives.

II. Facilitation

The Symposium's structure and approach was inspired by the Lighting the Way project's participatory Forum structures. Lighting the Way used Liberating Structures methodologies to generate input from all of the voices and perspectives in the room. Archivists in the Loop organizers designed the arc of presentations and discussion to generate consensus, gather diverse experiences and knowledge, and ultimately drive toward recommendations and resources for later outputs, as the Lighting the Way handbook did. The organizing team engaged an experienced facilitator, Jess Farrell of Redstart Works, to round out a three-facilitator team with Johnston and Courtney. Farrell had participated in Lighting the Way as a feedback provider on the handbook and trained with the Anti-Oppressive Resource and Training Alliance (AORTA).

All discussions were facilitated using participatory and inclusive techniques designed to create opportunities for every participant to contribute, draw out collective intelligence

and creativity, and build engagement to generate solutions to shared problems. Participants sat at tables that formed the basis for small group discussions. Each table contained a sticky note tabletop easel pad and several stacks of sticky notes.

During the Symposium many participants expressed interest in continuing to work together, and after the Symposium, facilitation continued. Interested participants joined a collaborative report writing group to write this report, and organizers supported weekly coworking sessions while writing together.

III. Agreements

At the end of the symposium, we used an activity inspired by Liberating Structures' 25/10 Crowdsourcing to quickly generate, exchange, and prioritize ideas from across the group. Participants generated "big ideas" individually, reviewed and scored one another's ideas, and then discussed the highest-scoring responses as a group to identify areas of broad agreement. Our goal was to identify areas of shared concern and possible collective action.

Our Top 10 Agreements:

1. Understanding user needs and perspectives is important in designing AI workflows, tools, and experiences.
2. We need to understand user information seeking behavior with AI, engaging in many more user studies.
3. We would benefit from a system that was designed by our professional community so that it has a higher chance of incorporating our concerns/requirements as opposed to utilizing corporate LLMs and AI products.
4. Discovery must allow for the traceability of information or digital objects.
5. Things are not binary when it comes to AI and archives (e.g. good or bad). We can imagine a path where AI can enhance archival practice while also allowing space for archival interrogation and critique.
6. We have a professional obligation to adjust practices given the advent of AI regardless of our personal convictions.
7. Being deeply engaged with AI topics, such as defining archival reference with AI, is critical to shaping its future.

8. We need more guidance for archivists that is developed collaboratively across the field.
9. There are opportunities for collective action.
10. AI (LLMs as tools) should serve the needs of human archivists, not replace them.